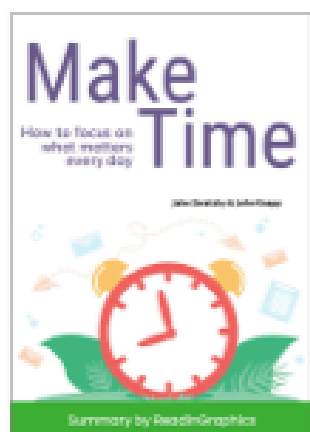




MAKE TIME

How to Focus on What Matters Every Day

JAKE KNAPP & JOHN ZERATSKY



The Big "So What"

This book is about making time for the things you truly *want* to do. Instead of trying to become more productive or cramming more into your day, change the default way you work and live to truly own your life.



Introduction

🕒 People in the 21st century are perpetually busy because of 2 things:

- The "Busy Bandwagon" refers to the hectic culture of modern societies. We're expected to respond quickly to everything, from an email to a new project. We keep trying to pack more into our schedule for fear of falling behind.
- Whenever we get a breather, we'll reach automatically for our phones and devices, only to get sucked into "Infinity Pools". These refer to apps or platforms with an endless supply of interesting content, e.g. newsfeeds, social media and video games.



Busy Bandwagon

+



Infinity Pool

=



No Time

- Caught between the Busy Bandwagon and Infinity Pool, we have no time by default. To regain control of your life, you must reset your default settings.

KEY QUOTES

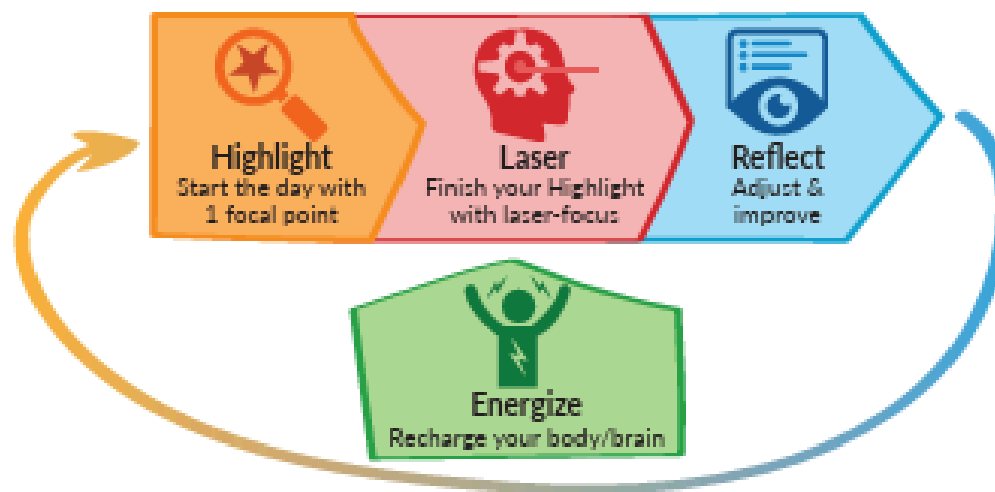
"There is more to life than increasing its speed."
—Mahatma Gandhi

"This is a book about slowing down the crazy rush. It's about making time for things that matter."



The authors (Jake and JZ) are product designers and self-proclaimed geeks who helped to build services like YouTube, Gmail, and Google Hangouts. Realizing how busy and distracted they were, they started to experiment with ways to make time for themselves, and to improve their focus and energy levels. Through their experiments, Jake finally found the time to start writing (something he'd wanted to do since young), while JZ finally started to live his dream of taking long sailing trips with his wife.

- The Make Time formula involves 4 daily steps: Highlight, Laser, Energize, and Reflect. These were inspired by design sprint principles (an innovation approach invented by Jake), the authors' personal experiments and feedback from readers who tried the approach.



- In the next sections, we'll explain these 4 steps with 87 tactics you can mix-and-match to customize your personal routine. Just choose any of the tactics below, try them out and repeat the process in a pick-test-repeat cycle.
 - Initially, just try 1 tactic for each of the 4 steps. Then, add new tactics or stick to the ones that work for you.
 - There's no need to be perfect. It's ok to keep changing and refining your system. You may also prefer different tactics for different situations (e.g. when you're in office or traveling).



1) Highlight: Start each day with 1 focal point

Doing more isn't the same as doing what matters. Start by (i) choosing 1 activity to prioritize for the day and (ii) protecting in your calendar.

KEY QUOTES

"Make Time is a framework for choosing what you want to focus on, building the energy to do it, and breaking the default cycle so that you can start being more intentional about the way you live your life."

"Perfection is a distraction—another shiny object taking your attention away from your real priorities."

"Something magic happens when you start the day with one high-priority goal."

★ Highlights are the bright spots that you look forward to each day. This is an activity, moment or achievement that you can savor when the day is over. It provides a focal point to keep you away from the Busy Bandwagon and the Infinity Pool.



You can choose your Highlight in one of 3 ways.

- Urgency: Go for something that's time-critical and must be completed that day. Ideally, the task should be mid-sized and important, e.g. sending a proposal to a customer, or helping your son to finish a school project.
- Satisfaction: Choose something you want to do, not something you need to do. Ideally, look at projects or activities that are not urgent, because these are the ones you're the most likely to defer indefinitely, e.g. researching your next vacation, or drafting the outline for a novel.
- Joy: Go for something you feel like doing that day, e.g. going to the beach, learning a new song on the piano.



Here are some useful points to note:

- Trust your intuition and just go with what feels right that day. If it doesn't work out, you can always try something different the next day, or change your highlight mid-day.
- Ideally, pick a Highlight that you can finish in 60-90 minutes. You can break it down further into several steps.
- Prioritize your Highlight over other daily activities.



Tactics for Choosing your Highlights



Write down your Highlight daily, ideally the previous night or the first thing in the morning. You can record it in a notebook, app, or calendar, though the authors recommend using sticky notes placed in prominent spots.



Repeat a previous Highlight. This is especially useful if (i) you didn't get to do or complete a Highlight, (ii) you wish to build a habit or gain momentum, or (iii) you really enjoyed that activity.

KEY QUOTES

*"We do not remember days, we remember moments."
—Cesare Pavese*

*"This isn't about saving time.
It's about making time for what matters."*

"You only waste time if you're not intentional about how you spend it."

"There's a special, almost magical power to writing down your plans: The things you write down are more likely to happen."



Rank your life priorities and use it as a guide.

- List down 3-10 major priorities in your life. Go for big categories that can be captured in 1-2 words, e.g. family, music, getting promoted.
- Choose the 1 most important thing, e.g. something that requires the most work, or something that you care about the most.
- Rank the other priorities and rewrite the list in order of priority.
- Circle out the top priority. Use this list to guide your daily priorities. You can reshuffle your priorities over time.



Combine several small, distracting tasks and use batch processing to clear them in 1 Highlight session.



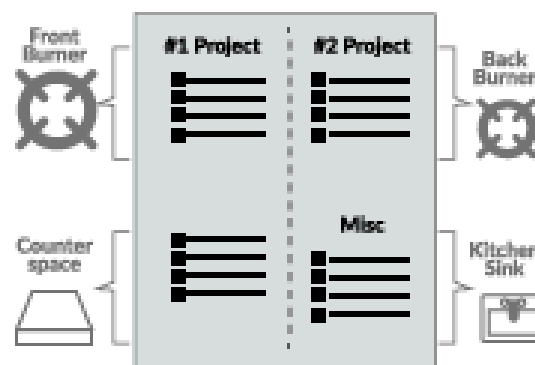
A long to-do list can distract you from what's important and create a nagging sense of incompleteness. What's worse, most to-do items reflect others' priorities (not yours). Change your to-do list to a might-do list. Prioritize time for your Highlight, then make an explicit decision on what else to do or ignore.



Alternatively, use a Burner List to focus on 1 big project and 1 small project at a time.

- Draw a line down a blank sheet of paper to create 2 columns.

- The top-left is your "front-burner". State your most important project, and break it down into the specific tasks that you must finish in the next few days.



- Leave some "counter space" on the bottom-left, where you can add more tasks for your #1 project later.
- On the top-right is your "back-burner", where you'll list your 2nd most important project and its related tasks.
- The bottom-right is your "kitchen sink" where you place all other items not associated with the 2 projects.

KEY QUOTES

"Most to-dos are just reactions to other people's priorities, not yours."

- When you're cooking, you'll focus on the front burner while occasionally tending to the back-burner. Using the same approach, you can clear a Burner list every few days.



You build momentum when you work on something for a few consecutive days. Run a personal sprint by breaking down a project into tasks scheduled over a few days in a row.



Tactics to Make Time for your Highlights



Decide how much time to spend on your Highlight, when to do it, and schedule it in your calendar.



Don't squeeze your Highlights into leftover pockets of time. Instead, block your calendar in advance. If others try to book you during these periods, politely decline and tell them that you already have plans. Start with 1-2 hours a day and adjust from there.



If your calendar is already packed, bulldoze your way by shortening or rescheduling other events to free up blocks of time.



If necessary, cancel/postpone low-priority commitments (e.g. cancel a meeting, delay a deadline or bail on a friend) to make time for your Highlights. Bear with the short-term pain until you regain some control over your schedule.



Say "no" to low-priority requests so you don't have to bulldoze or cancel later. Decline politely and honestly, e.g. "Sorry, I'm working on a couple of major projects and really don't have the time now."



Plan your entire day upfront, instead of reacting to ad-hoc requests by the hour. You can always adjust your plan as things evolve.



Mornings can be one of the best times for your Highlights. To become more effective in the mornings:

- Start your day with bright lights, coffee and a purpose. Turn on all the lights in your house, or use simulated lights to help your brain register that it's daytime (especially if you wake up pre-dawn).

KEY QUOTES

"Reacting to what's in front of you is always easier than doing what you intend."

"It's better to ruffle a few feathers than to always push your priorities off for 'someday.'"

"A structured day creates freedom."

- Plan for adequate sleep the previous night. Avoid alcohol or caffeine after dinner, and gradually wind down in the evenings.

★★ If you're more of a night-owl, it could be more productive to do your Highlights at night. Take a break before you begin, set a timer (and switch into "Highlight mode" once it goes off), and give yourself some time to wind down before you sleep.

✋ Don't try to cram as much as possible into your day. When you're exhausted, your work quality dips and the effects can spill over to the next day. Experiment to find your ideal cut-off time to stop work, or end your work day once you've completed your Highlight.

2) Laser: Remove distractions and be laser-focused

This step is about blocking out distractions so you can work with laser-sharp focus for extended periods of time.

💡 You'll naturally get in the zone when you (i) are doing something meaningful that you care about, (ii) have enough energy to focus, and (iii) can keep distractions at bay. That's why all 4 components in the Make Time formula are crucial.

- One of the best ways to remove distractions is to make it hard or inconvenient to access them in the first place.

Tactics to Regain Control over your Phone

🗑️ Make your phone distraction-free. Both the authors did this since 2012, and found themselves feeling happier, calmer and more focused.

- Delete all distracting apps including: (i) social apps (e.g. Facebook, Instagram, Twitter), (ii) other Infinity Pools (anything with infinite content, e.g. news, videos, games), (iii) web browser, and (iv) emails (you can still respond to emails on your laptops without constantly looking at them on your phone).

KEY QUOTES

"No matter how long you keep your foot on the accelerator, if the tank is empty, you aren't going anywhere."

"When distraction is hard to access, you don't have to worry about willpower. You can channel your energy into making time instead of wasting it."

"We fear being out of the loop, but once we're out there, we realize it's actually kind of nice."

- This may sound extreme, but at least try it out for 1 month, 1 week or even 1 day. You can always add back the apps later.

 Log out of your apps and websites every time. The hassle of entering your username and password will discourage you from accessing them unnecessarily.

 Turn off all notifications on your phone, except for the truly crucial ones (e.g. calendar reminders).

 Have a blank home-screen to get a moment of peace when you unlock your phone. Place all app icons from the 2nd screen onward so you need an extra step to access your apps.

 Wear a wristwatch so you don't have to unlock your phone just to check the time (and risk getting sucked in).

 Go offline periodically. Leave your devices in the office when you go home, or make them highly inaccessible (e.g. put them in a bag then lock the bag in a drawer).



Tactics to Stay Out of Infinity Pools

 Clean up your workspace at the end of each day. Sign out of all your accounts, hide the menu bars and turn off your email and chats, so you won't be flooded by notifications the minute you turn on your computer the next day.

 Delay your morning check-ins. When you wake up, don't check for updates at once. Use your calm and rested state in the mornings to enter the Laser mode and finish your Highlights.

 Each of us is susceptible to different distractions, e.g. Instagram, newsfeeds, email. Block your #1 distraction. Delete that app from your phone, log out each time, or at least turn it off during Laser time.

 Ignore breaking news. There's no need to follow the newsfeed 24/7. Just read the news once a week to stay up to date. If something is truly important, you'll hear about it somehow from other sources.

KEY QUOTES

"Notifications are not your friends. They're nonstop attention thieves."

"True breaking news will find you, and the rest isn't urgent or just doesn't matter."

 When you're traveling, don't turn on the screen or pay for wifi on the plane. Use the distraction-free environment for your Highlights.

 When you have unlimited access to the Internet, you'll be tempted to stay online. Restrict your Internet access by using a vacation timer or other software tools.

 Or, cancel your Internet access altogether. You'll still be able to find ways to go online if necessary, but these are likely to be less convenient and more costly. To deter excessive usage.

 Beware of time craters, i.e. small distractions that create huge disruptions. For example, a 20-minute meal can lead to a 2-hour food coma. A 30-second social media post might have you returning many times to read others' comments and respond to them.

 Ignore fake wins, such as social media "likes" or responses to emails which don't truly create an impact. Focus on your Highlights because that's where your real wins lie.

 Every successful app serves a purpose, even Infinity Pools. You can convert distracting apps into useful tools by changing how you use them:

- Define why you use an app, how it adds value to you, how much time you want to invest in that activity, and if that app is the best way to achieve your goal. For example, is Instagram the best way to stay in touch with your friends?
- Match the tools to your objectives, e.g. limit the time you spend on a tool, or switch to a better tool. JZ limits his Twitter access to 30min daily, and uses that time to share about his work and address readers' questions. Jake limits his browser time to 4min daily so he's hyper-deliberate about how he uses that time.

 Avid sports fans spend lots of time following every match and news update. You can still support your favorite team(s) by following some games/news and freeing up time for other priorities.

KEY QUOTES

"Small distractions create much larger holes in our day."



Tactics to Slow Down your Inbox

The faster you clear your emails, the faster people respond and expect instantaneous replies. So, the best way to manage your emails is actually to slow them down.



Check your emails at the end of the day. Reserve your peak hours for your Highlights.



Schedule email time in your calendar and only manage emails during the allotted time.



Clear your inbox once a week. You can glance through your inbox daily, but only reply to those that truly require a response.



Treat your emails as letters. We typically take a few days to open and respond to snail mail. Do the same for your emails.



People email you about their priorities when it's convenient for them. Answer your messages in batches and respond as slowly as possible—take hours, days or even weeks before you reply. If something is really urgent and important, they'll find a way to contact you.



Manage expectations with a message like "I'm busy with a few important projects and will be slow to respond. Please send me a text if your message is urgent."



Set up "send-only emails" on your phone so you can still send reminders, notes or materials without dealing with a busy inbox.



Go off the grid when you're on vacation. Delete your email app and Infinity Pools, leave your laptop behind and enjoy your holiday fully.



If you lack the willpower to stay away from your emails, use software or apps to lock yourself out (except during pre-allotted time slots).

KEY QUOTES

"Instant-response insanity is our culture's default behavior."



Tactics to Reduce TV Time

Most of us spend way too much time on TV. Make it an occasional treat instead of a default leisure activity.



Stop watching the news. It's much better to read the news once a day or once a week.



Place your TV in an inconspicuous corner of the room.



Replace the TV with a projector. It's more troublesome to set it up, so you'll use it less but can enjoy a cinema-like experience for special occasions.



Cancel all subscriptions with unlimited content, and only buy/rent ala-carte movies or episodes.



Go cold-turkey for a month. Unplug your TV and store it away. After 1 month, you may decide it's not worth bringing it back out.



Tactics to Get in Flow



Close the door and/or put on your headphones to signal to yourself and others that it's Laser/focus time.



Invent a deadline so you'll be motivated to finish your Highlight. Get a friend to hold you accountable, or register for an event (e.g. a 10km run) that you must work toward.



Break down your Highlights into small, easy-to-do tasks. Express them using action verbs, e.g. "research airfares for vacation".



Use music as a cue. Play a song or album each time you start on a Highlight, and reserve those song(s) exclusively for Laser time. After a while, your brain will automatically enter a focused state when you play the music. You can even have different music for different types of Highlights.



Use a visible timer that shows how much time you've used and how much time is left. This will motivate you to stay focused.

KEY QUOTES

*"The closed door is your way of telling the world and yourself that you mean business."
—Stephen King*

"Tiny doable to-dos help you build momentum and lock into Laser mode."

 Stick to simple tools that are always available and reliable. Don't bother with fancy tools which can complicate things or break down.

 It's easier to get into Laser mode when you start on paper instead of a screen, since you think differently on paper, and won't get distracted by things like font type or size.



Tactics to Stay in the Zone

 During your Highlights, park random questions and issues on a separate list as they pop up, so you won't go off-track.

 To stop the clutter in your head, pause and focus on 1 breath. Notice how the air enters through your nose and fills your lungs, and how your body relaxes as you breath out through your mouth.

 Learn to sit with your boredom and let your mind wander. Creative ideas often emerge from such moments.

 When you're stuck, allow the problem to incubate in your mind as you take a walk, switch to screen/paper, etc.

 If you can't get in Laser mode no matter what, then take a day off to do something truly enjoyable and energizing.

 Sometimes, you can't get/stay in the zone because your heart isn't really in it. Switch to a task you can immerse in wholeheartedly.



3) Energize: Recharge your body and brain

You need energy to stay disciplined and focused, so make sure you recharge your body and brain throughout the day.

 Our body is like a battery. When your battery is flat, it's hard to think clearly or resist Infinity Pools. When your battery is full, you feel sharp, alive and ready to take on the world.

 Since homo sapiens first appeared on Earth ≈200,000 years ago, we've led a hunter-gatherer lifestyle which involved (i) a wide variety of natural foods, (ii) constant movement

KEY QUOTES

and (iii) lots of leisure time for human connection. This changed drastically in the last 12,000 years due to the agricultural, industrial and infotech revolutions. Today, our modern lifestyle has become extremely out of sync with our hunter-gatherer bodies. The good news is, we can recharge our bodies naturally by incorporating simple daily practices.



Tactics to Keep Moving



One of the best ways to recharge your body is to exercise daily in moderation.

- Ideally, exercise for ≈20mins daily to develop a habit.
- If that's too ambitious, then do what's doable and celebrate every progress. Even exercising for 10mins 3-4x a week can make a difference.



The human body is designed for walking. This can be easily incorporated *into* your daily activities, instead of adding it *on top* of them. For example, you can walk to work instead of taking the train, park your car farther from the building, and use your walking time to think, plan and reflect.



Choose "energizing" over "convenience". Try cooking (and moving around the kitchen) instead of eating out, or taking the stairs instead of the elevator.



Go for super-short, intense workouts (e.g. pushups, weights, squats, lunges) to recharge your battery quickly in just a few minutes.



Tactics for Eating Real Food



Adopt a hunter-gatherer diet, i.e. eat whole, unprocessed foods like fruits, vegetables, nuts, seafood and meat.



Fill the center of your plate with salad or greens before adding other denser, higher-calorie foods.



Try intermittent fasting, e.g. have an early dinner, skip breakfast and have a big lunch, so you'll go almost 16 hours without food.

KEY QUOTES

"If you want energy for your brain, you need to take care of your body."

*"What you do every day matters more than what you do once in a while."
—Gretchen Rubin*



Alternatively, snack throughout the day: consume quality snacks and eat only when your brain/body requires it.



Replace sugary desserts with dark chocolate, which has less sugar and a host of health benefits.



Tactics for Using Caffeine Optimally

Caffeine doesn't give you extra energy; it simply blocks the signals from *adenosine* which tells your brain that you're sleepy. Once the caffeine wears off, the *adenosine* can hit you all at once to cause headaches or fatigue. So, caffeine should be used intentionally and optimally.



You don't need caffeine first thing in the morning since your body typically produces high levels of cortisol around 8-9am to help you wake up fully. Take your first dose of caffeine around 9.30-10.30am when your cortisol level starts to drop.



As a rule of thumb, caffeinate 30 minutes before your energy dips, e.g. just after lunch at around 1.30pm or 2.30pm.



If you're already tired, then take some caffeine followed by a 15-minute caffeine nap. By the time you wake up, your body would've absorbed the caffeine.



Use caffeine for a turbo boost before you start on your Highlight.



Maintain your energy levels throughout the day by substituting 1 large dose of caffeine (e.g. a big cup of coffee) with smaller doses of caffeine (e.g. 2-3 cups of green tea).



After 5-6 hours, half of the caffeine will still be in your system. So, you should generally avoid coffee after 4pm to avoid disrupting your sleep at night. Run your own experiments to figure out your ideal cut-off time.



Many caffeinated drinks come with lots of sugar. Where possible, choose caffeine without sugar (e.g. unsweetened tea/coffee).

KEY QUOTES



Tactics for Getting Off the Grid



Spend some time with nature and fresh air, e.g. go for a stroll in the park, or a hike in the forest.



Calm your mind. Try meditation, which is basically about being still and noticing your thoughts (instead of actively thinking them). You can try variants like using a guided meditation app, or simply having some quiet time.



Resist the urge to fill your mind every minute of the day. Occasionally leave your headphones at home when you walk, jog, or go about your day.



Take real breaks by moving around, talking to people, or gazing out of the window. Stay away from the screen or Infinity Pools as they'll tax you (not rejuvenate you).



Tactics for Making Human Connections



All humans need human connection. So, spend time with people, especially interesting or high-energy people you enjoy being around. Go for face-to-face interactions or phone conversations (i.e. exchanges that involve your voice). Observe your energy levels after each interaction to identify the energy-givers vs energy-sappers.



Avoid screens during meals. Use the time to interact with people, enjoy your meal, or just give your brain some quiet time.



Tactics for Improving your Sleep Quality



Create a conducive sleep environment. Gradually reduce the mental stimuli at the end of your work day so you can wind down. Ideally, keep all devices (including phones and TV) out of the bedroom. Use a physical alarm clock and read paper books/magazines. If you must read digital content, use a distraction-free device.

KEY QUOTES

"Meditation is just a breather for your brain."

"Resist the itch to fill the blank space."



Simulate the sunset/sunrise. Our body uses light to gauge when it's time to sleep or wake.

- Fake your own sunset: (i) turn down the lights in your home
- in the evening, (ii) switch all electrical gadgets to "night mode" and leave them outside the bedroom, and (iii) make your bedroom as dark as possible (or wear an eye-mask).
- If you still feel lethargic in the morning, try simulating a sunrise using LED lights.



Take short naps to recharge and refresh.



Don't sacrifice sleep during weekdays, then try to catch up on sleep over the weekends. You can't clear your sleep-debts that way. Instead, maintain your energy levels daily, regardless of whether it's a weekday or weekend.



In an airplane emergency, you're reminded to wear your oxygen mask first before you try to help others. Likewise, take care of your physical and emotional needs first, so you have the energy for things that matter.



4) Reflect: Adjust and improve your system

Use a few simple notes to reflect on your day and decide on the tactics to continue, refine or drop.



The 87 tactics above came from the authors' research and experiments. However, what worked for them may not work for you. This final step is about refining your strategies/tactics to suit your lifestyle and goals, using a 4-part scientific approach:

- Observe what's happening;
- Hypothesize why it's happening;
- Run experiments to test your hypothesis; and
- Measure the outcomes.



Take notes daily to track what works for you:

KEY QUOTES

- Record (i) your Highlight for the day, (ii) whether you made time for it, (iii) your Laser/focus level (on a scale of 1-10), (iv) your Energy level (on a scale of 1-10), (v) the tactics you tried and how they turned out, and (vi) the tactics to try the next day.
- Record a moment you were grateful for that day.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book



You don't have to try everything in this book. Just take baby steps to start making time for what you care about, instead of waiting to do them "someday". If you're still unsure about where to start, simply try out these tactics for 3 days, then decide what to keep or adjust:

1. Highlight	2. Laser	3. Energize	4. Reflect
Schedule your Highlight to own your day.	Block your #1 distraction for a day and see how it feels.	Walk a few minutes a day.	Take notes each evening.



This a fun, humorous book packed with illustrations, personal snippets and anecdotes, including the authors' own experiments and experiences. The book also includes sample templates, reading lists and extracts from Jake/JZ's typical day. For more details and free tools/tips, please visit maketimebook.com

About the Authors

Jake Knapp is an American author and designer. He spent 10 years at Google and Google Ventures, where he invented the Design Sprint process. Jake also co-founded Google Meet and helped to build products like Gmail and Microsoft Encarta. He has written two books, *Sprint* and *Make Time*, and coaches teams on design strategy and time management. For more details, visit <https://jakeknapp.com>.



KEY QUOTES

"The goal is to make time for what matters, find more balance, and enjoy today a little more."

"Do not ask yourself what the world needs. Ask yourself what makes you come alive, and then go do that. Because what the world needs is people who have come alive."
—Howard Thurman